

School closure scenarios: what to weigh before deciding

District 65 needs to cut about 10% of its budget. We looked at class sizes, the options on the table, our staffing against the State's funding model, building costs and the closure scenarios.

WHAT SHOULD GUIDE THE PLAN

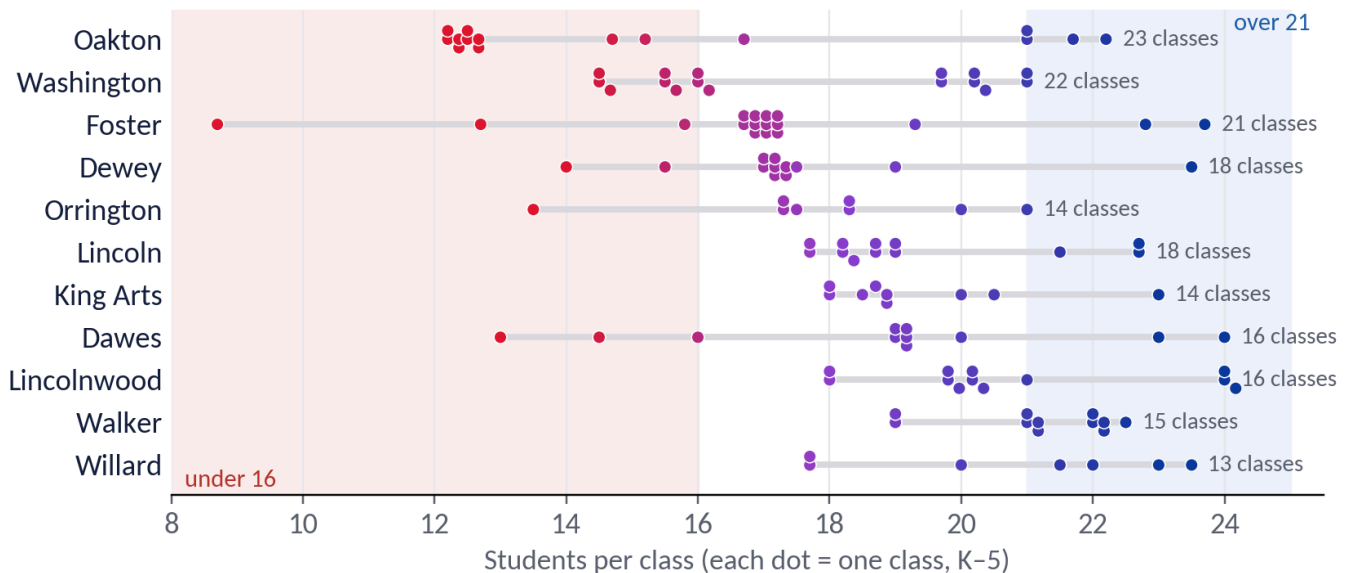
- 1 Decide by outcomes, not dollars.** Orient decisions and accountability toward what students learn, and judge every cut by its effect on the classroom.
- 2 Build a learning organization.** Use data to improve, and be willing to say when something didn't work and change course.
- 3 Engaged families are an asset.** Community groups like ours are part of a healthy district. When parents check out, the system has already failed.

RISK ASSESSMENT: A BUILDING-FIRST PLAN

- HIGH Enrollment numbers are off**
May projection: **604** kindergartners; fall actual: **534 (-12%)**.
About **210** students attend by permissive transfer.
- HIGH Receiving schools overflow**
7 of 15 scenarios push a school past capacity.
- HIGH Low-enrollment programs**
Closing TWI, ACC or STEP buildings means **moving whole programs**.
- HIGH One-time costs and special ed**
Costs **come before savings**; IEP services must continue **uninterrupted**.
- HIGH A two-tier system**
Families who can afford it **opt for private school**, leaving D65 with fewer resources and less engaged support.
- MEDIUM Transportation costs**
\$150-270K a year per closure, 20-35% of building savings.
- MEDIUM Equity**
Closures land on **specific neighborhoods** and TWI access.
- MEDIUM Attention is finite**
Closure planning takes time that **staffing decisions** need.

CLASS SIZE AND THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

A child's class size depends on their school and grade



Classes run from about 12 to 24 students.
Of 190 estimated K-5 classes, **36 have under 16** and **37 have over 21**.

Same grade, different school: a 3rd grader at Oakton is in a class of **12-15**; at Lincoln, about **21-22**.

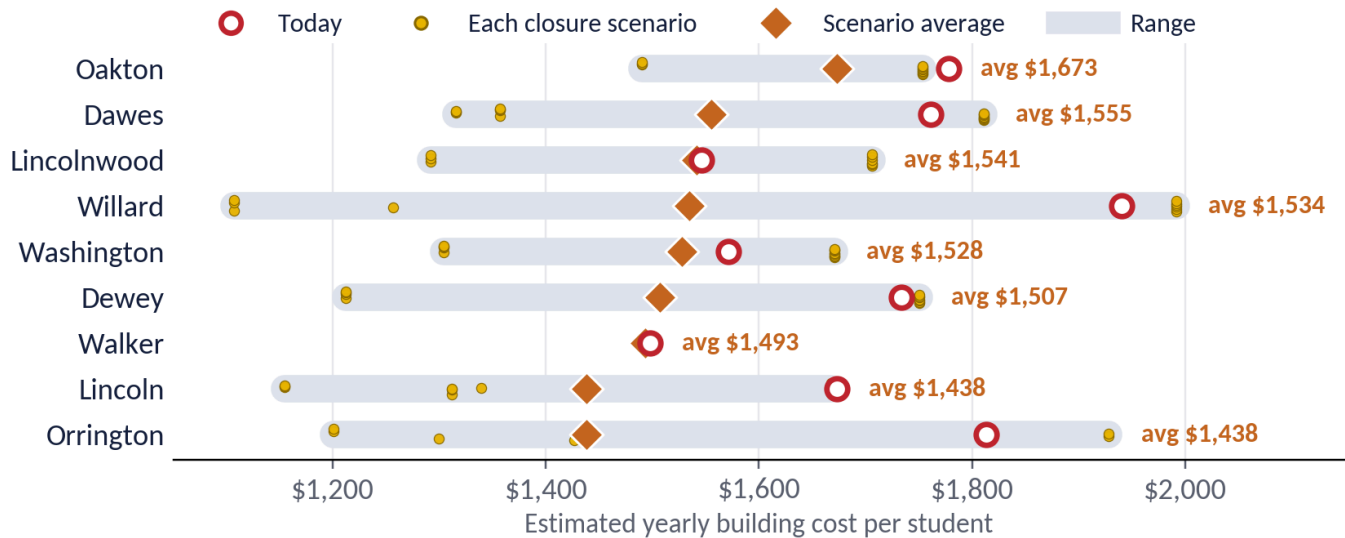
Fuller buildings don't have bigger classes ($r = -0.11$). The spread comes from **how grades divide into classes** and from TWI and ACC strands.

01 BUILDING COSTS

Which buildings cost the most to run?

Every building carries a principal, an office and custodians whatever its size, so **emptier buildings cost more per student**. At the average closure-scenario enrollment, **Oakton, Dawes and Lincolnwood** cost the most per student; **Lincoln and Orrington** the least.

BUILDING COST PER STUDENT: TODAY, EACH CLOSURE SCENARIO, AND THE AVERAGE



BUILDING	STUDENTS	UTILIZATION NOW → AVG*	PRINCIPAL + OFFICE	CUSTODIANS	UTILITIES	TOTAL A YEAR	PER STUDENT NOW	PER STUDENT SCENARIO AVG*
Oakton	367	79% → 84%	\$241K	\$345K	\$66K	\$652K	\$1,778	\$1,673
Dawes	288	67% → 75%	\$241K	\$209K	\$58K	\$507K	\$1,761	\$1,555
Lincolnwood	331	77% → 77%	\$241K	\$221K	\$50K	\$512K	\$1,546	\$1,541
Willard	273	51% → 65%	\$241K	\$227K	\$62K	\$530K	\$1,940	\$1,534
Washington	387	73% → 75%	\$241K	\$278K	\$90K	\$608K	\$1,571	\$1,528
Dewey	315	59% → 67%	\$241K	\$236K	\$70K	\$546K	\$1,734	\$1,507
Walker	317	73% → 74%	\$241K	\$186K	\$48K	\$475K	\$1,498	\$1,493
Lincoln	350	61% → 71%	\$241K	\$266K	\$79K	\$585K	\$1,673	\$1,438
Orrington	251	58% → 73%	\$241K	\$170K	\$45K	\$455K	\$1,813	\$1,438
King Arts	445	68%	\$241K	\$362K	\$101K	\$703K	\$1,580	—
Haven (MS)	604	65%	\$241K	\$514K	\$96K	\$850K	\$1,408	—
Chute (MS)	591	75%	\$241K	\$408K	\$102K	\$752K	\$1,272	—
Nichols (MS)	582	83%	\$241K	\$354K	\$83K	\$678K	\$1,164	—

WHAT STANDS OUT

Adding students lowers cost per student only at receiving buildings; the district saves just the closed building's costs. **Utilities are a small share:** \$1.33M district-wide.

DATA WE STILL NEED

Maintenance and capital needs by building (10-year Health/Life Safety survey, facility assessment), likely larger than utilities; **actual building staff by school**; **site-level spending per student** (ISBE report card); **full-year 2026 utilities**.

*Scenario average = today's cost ÷ the building's average 2027–28 enrollment across the closure scenarios on page 3 where it stays open and at or under capacity (90% of displaced students stay). Foster has no utility account. **Sources:** D65 dashboard (2025 utilities, energy use; pulled 9/23/2026); square feet derived from energy use ÷ EUI; fall 2026 enrollment (D65 dashboard); capacity = smaller of the district's Cap Total and Cordogan Clark (2022); principal pay, FY26 PA 96-0434 salary report (\$180,753 average); 64 custodians from the district's employee-category table, allocated by square feet. **Assumed:** custodian pay \$65K and office staff \$60K per building. Built with help from Claude (AI); please verify.

What closures would do to the receiving schools

Each closed school's projected 2027–28 students go to its receiving schools, with 90% staying in D65. Pairs close one south school (Dewey, Washington or Oakton) and one north school (Willard, Lincolnwood or Orrington). "Kept together" sends a school to one building; "split" divides it by open seats.

	Dawes	Dewey	Foster	Lincoln	Lincolnwood	Oakton	Orrington	Walker	Washington	Willard
No closures	65%	58%	58%	61%	69%	80%	55%	74%	69%	50%
1. Close Dewey <i>split → 3 schools</i>	65%	closed	76%	78%	69%	80%	74%	74%	69%	50%
2. Close Orrington <i>kept together → 1 school</i>	65%	58%	58%	61%	69%	80%	closed	74%	69%	90%
3a. Close Lincolnwood <i>kept together → 1 school</i>	65%	58%	58%	61%	closed	80%	117%!	74%	69%	50%
3b. Close Lincolnwood <i>split → 2 schools</i>	65%	58%	58%	61%	closed	80%	81%	74%	69%	79%
3c. Close Lincolnwood <i>kept together → 1 school</i>	65%	58%	58%	61%	closed	80%	55%	74%	69%	101%!
4. Close Oakton <i>split → 3 schools</i>	87%	84%	58%	61%	69%	closed	55%	74%	88%	50%
Dewey + Willard <i>Dewey split 3 ways · Willard split 2 ways</i>	65%	closed	76%	78%	92%	80%	107%!	74%	69%	closed
Dewey + Lincolnwood <i>Dewey split 3 ways · Lincolnwood kept together</i>	65%	closed	76%	78%	closed	80%	136%!	74%	69%	50%
Dewey + Orrington <i>Dewey split 3 ways · Orrington kept together</i>	65%	closed	74%	76%	69%	80%	closed	74%	69%	109%!
Washington + Willard <i>Washington split 3 ways · Willard split 2 ways</i>	89%	58%	58%	88%	92%	94%	88%	74%	closed	closed
Washington + Lincolnwood <i>Washington split 3 ways · Lincolnwood kept together</i>	89%	58%	58%	88%	closed	94%	117%!	74%	closed	50%
Washington + Orrington <i>Washington split 3 ways · Orrington kept together</i>	89%	58%	58%	88%	69%	94%	closed	74%	closed	90%
Oakton + Willard <i>Oakton split 3 ways · Willard split 2 ways</i>	87%	84%	58%	61%	92%	closed	88%	74%	88%	closed
Oakton + Lincolnwood <i>Oakton split 3 ways · Lincolnwood kept together</i>	87%	84%	58%	61%	closed	closed	117%!	74%	88%	50%
Oakton + Orrington <i>Oakton split 3 ways · Orrington kept together</i>	87%	84%	58%	61%	69%	closed	closed	74%	88%	90%

Under 70% (lighter = emptier)

70–89%

90% and up

! = over capacity. Capacity = smaller of district Cap Total and Cordogan Clark. Receiving schools and splits as described in closure_scenarios.md.

ONE CLOSURE

Dewey, split three ways, leaves every receiver at 74–78%, but its TWI strand needs a new home. Orrington kept together fills Willard to 90% and all 24 of its classrooms.

Lincolnwood kept together doesn't fit: Orrington would reach 117%, with 23 classes for 19 classrooms. Sent whole to Willard instead, it lands right at the limit (101%, 25 classes for 24 classrooms). Splitting it between Orrington and Willard fits (81% and 79%), but every grade is divided between two schools. STEP moves either way.

Oakton, the fullest building today, splits three ways into Dawes, Washington and Dewey at 84–88%. Washington would use all 24 classrooms, and Oakton's TWI strand and ACC program both need new hosts.

TWO CLOSURES

Four pairs keep every receiver under capacity: Washington or Oakton, paired with Willard or Orrington. Even these reach 90–94% somewhere, and each moves at least one TWI strand.

Every pair with Dewey or Lincolnwood overfills Orrington or Willard, up to 136%. TWI at Dewey, Washington and Oakton, ACC at Oakton and STEP at Lincolnwood make relocation costly. Each pair could lose 30–100 students from the district.

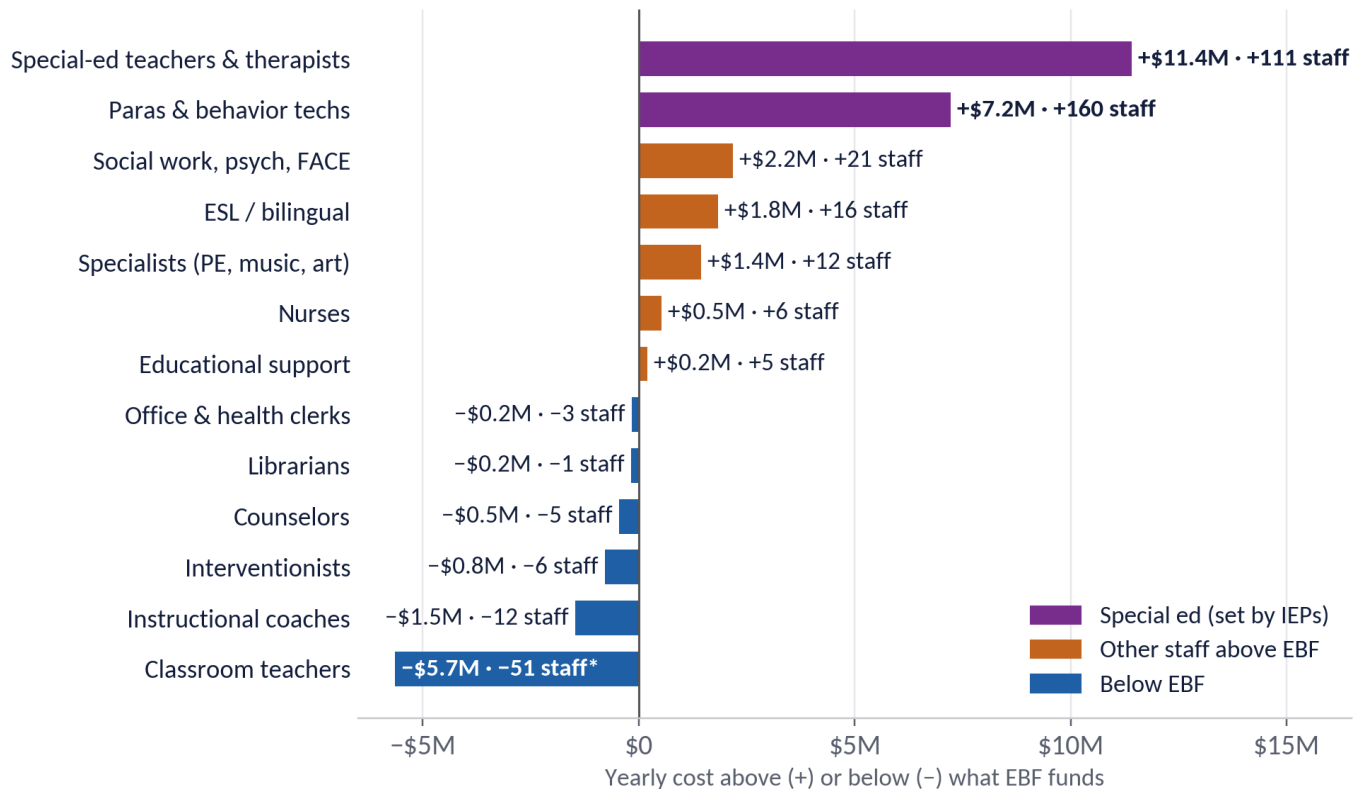
Projection: grades roll forward one year; incoming K = this year's K. Capacity = smaller of the district's Cap Total and Cordogan Clark. Washington's receivers follow the district's SDRP 3D table; Willard's and Oakton's are assumed from geography. Full tables at 85%, 90% and 95% retention are in closure_scenarios.md. Estimates built with help from Claude (AI); please verify.

03

STATE FUNDING MODEL (EBF)

How K-5 staffing compares with Evidence-Based Funding

Illinois's Evidence-Based Funding formula sets out how many staff the State pays for. On paper, D65 has about 252 more K-5 staff than EBF funds, worth \$15.9M a year. Special education explains all of that difference.



+\$18.6M

Special-ed teachers, therapists and paras above EBF's ratio of 1 teacher and 1 aide per 141 students. Staffing follows IEPs and federal law, so this can't simply be cut to match.

+\$6.2M

Other groups above EBF: social workers and psychologists (\$2.2M), ESL teachers (\$1.8M), specialists (\$1.4M), nurses (\$0.5M).

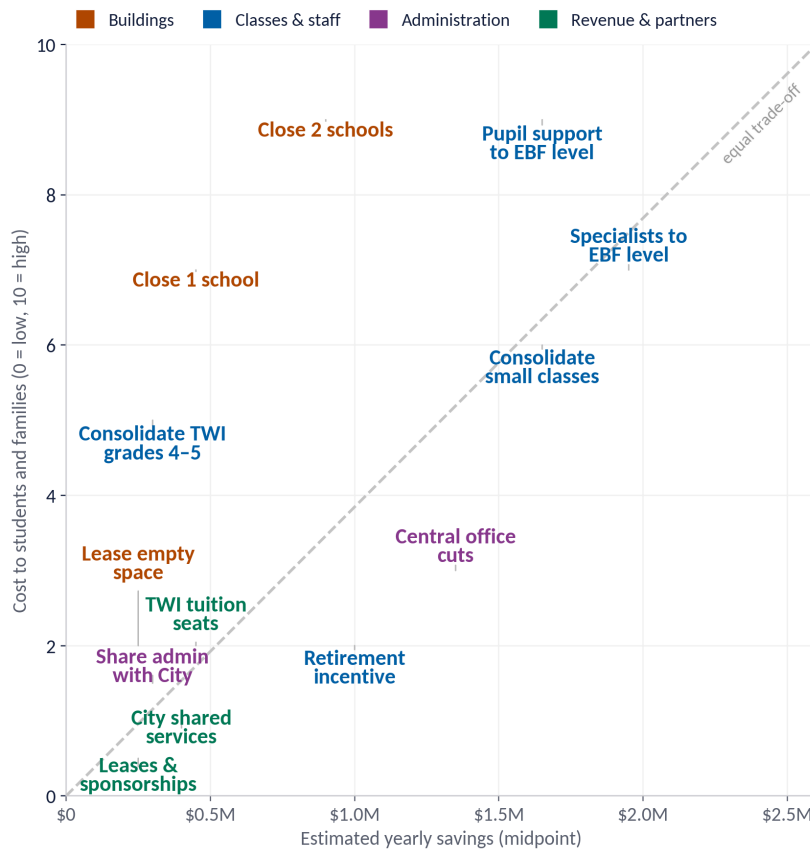
-\$8.9M

Where we're below EBF: classroom teachers, instructional coaches (6 vs. 18), interventionists and counselors.

K-5 STAFFING	1 SCHOOL	9 SCHOOLS	10 SCHOOLS	11 (TODAY)
Staff EBF funds	419	452	467	492
Staff we have (est.)	745	745	745	745
Yearly cost above EBF	\$24.4M	\$20.6M	\$18.8M	\$15.9M
Special ed and paras	\$18.6M	\$18.6M	\$18.6M	\$18.6M
Everything else	\$5.8M	\$1.9M	\$0.2M	-\$2.7M

EBF is a funding model, not a staffing rule. *The classroom-teacher figure is an upper bound: split evenly over 11 buildings, every grade rounds up to 3 classes. Staff other than classroom teachers are estimated for K-5 at 64% of the district count. Some non-teaching pay is assumed. Ratios from 105 ILCS 5/18-8.15.

What each option saves, and what it costs students



Plotting savings against harm puts the choices side by side. Options under the dashed line save more for less disruption to students and families.

WHERE THE MONEY IS

Consolidating small classes, bringing specialist and support staffing closer to EBF levels, and central-office cuts each save \$1–2.5M a year. One closure saves \$0.2–0.7M.

SMALL BUT LOW-HARM

Leasing empty space, TWI tuition seats, shared City services and sponsorships each bring in \$0.1–0.6M, with little effect on classrooms.

ABOUT THE SCORES

The cost-to-students scores are a first draft for discussion. The savings ranges are rough; items marked "estimate" below are illustrative.

OPTION	YEARLY SAVINGS	HOW WE ESTIMATED IT
● Close 1 school	\$0.2–0.7M	Building-use analysis: building savings minus added busing (net per closure)
● Close 2 schools	\$0.4–1.4M	Two times the per-closure net; relocation and renovation costs not included
● Lease or share empty space	\$0.1–0.4M	<i>Estimate</i> : preschool or community partner leases in underused wings
● Consolidate small classes	\$1.1–2.2M	10–20 fewer sections × ~\$111K average teacher pay (EBF analysis)
● Consolidate TWI strands in grades 4–5	\$0.2–0.4M	2–4 fewer upper-grade TWI sections × ~\$111K
● Specialist teachers to EBF level	\$1.4–2.5M	12–22 FTE above EBF × ~\$115K (EBF Table 3)
● Pupil support to EBF level	\$1.1–2.2M	Half to all of the 21 social work/psych/FACE FTE above EBF × ~\$103K
● Voluntary retirement incentive	\$0.5–1.5M	<i>Estimate</i> : 25–40 retirements replaced at lower step pay net of incentive
● Central office admin cuts	\$0.9–1.8M	<i>Estimate</i> : 5–10 central office positions × ~\$180K total comp
● Share admin services with City	\$0.1–0.5M	<i>Estimate</i> : shared office space and personnel (creative ideas menu)
● TWI tuition seats	\$0.3–0.6M	<i>Estimate</i> : 20–40 tuition students × ~\$15K
● City shared services	\$0.2–0.6M	<i>Estimate</i> : crossing guards maintenance purchasing (creative ideas menu)
● Cell tower, solar and sponsorship revenue	\$0.1–0.4M	<i>Estimate</i> : cell tower, solar panel and facility sponsorship revenue (creative ideas menu)

What families should hear: priorities, what they get, and how we'll know

Families will judge any plan by what happens in their child's classroom. The plan should say plainly what it protects, what changes, and how the district will show it's working.

OUR PRIORITIES

What comes first

- **Class sizes in a set range** for every grade at every school
- **Children stay with their classmates and teachers** wherever possible
- **Programs families chose stay whole:** TWI, ACC, STEP
- **Every IEP is fully served**, through any change
- **Savings reinvested** where EBF says we're short: coaching and intervention

WHAT FAMILIES GET

What changes for them

- **Predictable class sizes**, published for each school and grade
- **No building moves next school year**
- **More reading and math intervention** as savings are reinvested
- **A clear budget:** what was cut, what it saved, where it went

EDUCATIONAL OUTCOMES

How we'll know it's working

- **Class size by school and grade**, every fall
- **Reading and math growth** by school and student group
- **Attendance and chronic absence**
- **Special-ed service minutes delivered** vs. IEPs
- **Families staying in D65:** transfers in, out and to private schools

SCORECARD TO PUBLISH EACH TERM

MEASURE	WHAT WOULD TRIGGER A SECOND LOOK	REPORTED
Class size	Any grade above the agreed range, or below it two years running	Each fall
Reading and math growth	A school or student group falling behind its prior year	Winter, spring
Attendance	Chronic absence rising at a school affected by a change	Each term
Special-ed services	Any gap between minutes in IEPs and minutes delivered	Each term
Enrollment and transfers	Kindergarten or transfers off projection by more than 5%	Fall, spring
Savings	Actual savings below the plan, or one-time costs above it	Each budget cycle

KEY MESSAGES

"We're protecting what happens in the classroom first: class sizes, programs, and every child's services."

"We'll make the biggest savings where they do the least harm, and we'll show our work."

The class-size range and trigger thresholds are for the district and community to set; the ones here are starting points for discussion.



RECAP

The whole brief on one page

1-3.5%

of the \$20M target from one closure, after busing (\$0.2-0.7M a year)

\$18.6M

special-ed staffing above EBF's ratio: the whole gap, set by IEPs

7 of 15

closure scenarios push a receiving school over capacity

\$1,940

per student to run Willard today, the costliest building; \$1,500 at Walker

TAKEAWAYS

1. **Class size depends on school and grade**, from about 12 to 24 students, not on how full a building is ($r = -0.11$). p. 1
2. **Emptier buildings cost more per student**: \$1,500-1,950 today. Receivers get cheaper per student, but the district saves only the closed building's costs. p. 2
3. **Where students go decides if a closure fits**. Every scenario that overfills sends students into Orrington or Willard; TWI, STEP and ACC moves are costly. p. 3
4. **Special ed explains the whole EBF gap**. Without it we're \$2.7M below the model, and short on coaches and interventionists. p. 4
5. **Staffing and class structure save more**: \$1-2.5M each, against \$0.2-0.7M per closure. p. 5
6. **Tell families what's protected**, what they get, and publish a scorecard each term. p. 6

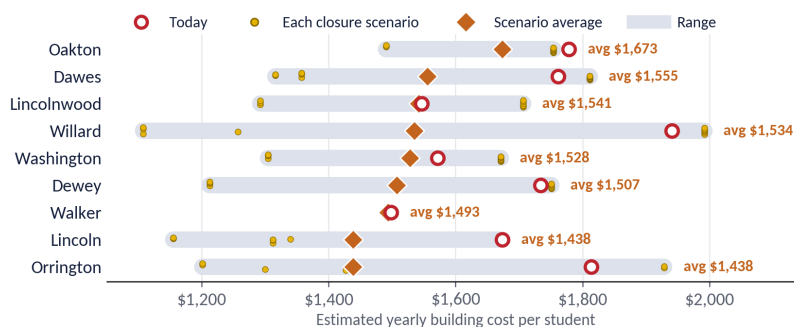
WHAT WE'RE ASKING

What to convey in the plan

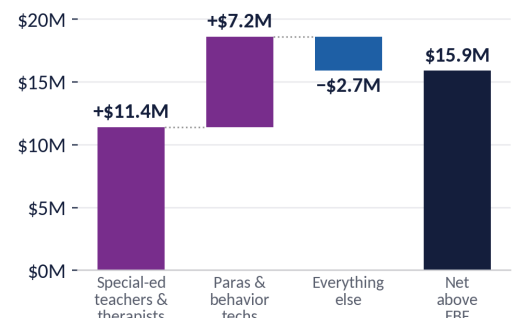
1. Itemized savings from the Kingsley and Bessie Rhodes closures, net of opening Foster.
2. The full cost of closing and relocating a school, including TWI, STEP and ACC moves.
3. Which positions would be cut, by category, and what each saves.
4. Class counts and class sizes by grade, before and after, not just utilization.
5. How the plan improves outcomes for students, not only this year's budget.

Decide by outcomes, learn from the data, and treat engaged families as an asset. We need to work with the buildings and the district we have.

BUILDING COST PER STUDENT



STAFFING ABOVE EBF



UTILIZATION IN EVERY CLOSURE SCENARIO, 2027-28

	Dawes	Dewey	Foster	Lincoln	Lincolnwood	Oakton	Orrington	Walker	Washington	Willard
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2. Orrington	65%	58%	58%	61%	69%	80%		74%	69%	90%
3a. Lincolnwood → Orrington	65%	58%	58%	61%		80%	117%!	74%	69%	50%
3b. Lincolnwood (split)	65%	58%	58%	61%		80%	81%	74%	69%	79%
3c. Lincolnwood → Willard	65%	58%	58%	61%		80%	55%	74%	69%	101%!
4. Oakton	87%	84%	58%	61%	69%		55%	74%	88%	50%
Dewey + Willard	65%		76%	78%	92%	80%	107%!	74%	69%	
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